Khān (Figure 1). Timur was in the tenth generation while Ghengis was in the fifth generation.

Babur's ancestors were sharply distinguished from the classical Mongols (Moghūls) insofar as they were oriented towards Persian rather than Turco-Mongol culture. According to John Joseph Saunders, 'Timur was "the product of an *Islamized and Iranized* society", and not steppe nomadic (Mongols).' [*]

If one looks at Timur's character, he was an opportunist. Taking advantage of his Turco-Mongolian heritage, he frequently used either the religion of Islam, *Sharia* law, *fiqh*, or traditions of the Mongol Empire to achieve his military goals and domestic political aims. This exactly was the trait of those whom we call Moghūls from the period of AD 1526 onwards. They had all the barbaric traits of the steppe nomads, but the same would be reflected when Persian strategies failed to core.

Though barbaric, the Mongol Empire was known to be highly secular and tolerant towards all existing faiths. In fact, after having given protection to the Muslims, Genghis Khān earned the title of 'Defender of Religions'.[†] What is very interesting is that the Mongol passion for religious tolerance charmed the European writers of the eighteenth century very broadly. Edward Gibbon, an English historian, writes in a celebrated passage, 'The Catholic inquisitors of Europe, who defended nonsense by cruelty, might have been confounded by the example of a barbarian, who anticipated the lessons of philosophy and established by his laws a system of pure theism and perfect toleration.' He goes on to add, in a footnote that 'singular conformity may be found between the religious laws of Zingis Khān and Mr. Locke'. [*] Well, for people who don't know about John Locke (29 August 1632–28 October 1704), he was an English philosopher and physician, widely regarded as one of the most influential 'enlightenment thinkers' and commonly known as the 'Father of Liberalism'.[†] He had influenced people like Voltaire.[‡] Perhaps the European idea of *imperialism* had a façade of *liberalism* and *secularism*, which appeared as a cool buttress.

In contrast, Timur had a record of persecution in the name of religion. As explained earlier, Timur had a high Persian influence. Before he could lay the siege of Persia, the condition of Christians was already horrendous with the rise of Islam as the 'state religion' for long.

The history of the church in Asia in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries was very much tied up with the rise of the Mongol/Moghūl power under Hulegu, Kublai and Timur. The first two were brothers, sons of the Nestorian